national ambitions, is involved in several scams in the state. In neighbouring Andhra Pradesh, where the ruling Yuvajana Sramika Rythu Congress Party (YSRCP) swept all the 25 Lok Sabha seats in 2019, the game is to ensure that chief minister Y.S. Jagan Mohan Reddy will side with the BJP if there is a show of strength in the Lok Sabha. The BJP can always turn the screws on Jagan as both the CBI and the ED are investigating several charges of misdemeanours committed by him when his father, the late Y.S. Rajasekhara Reddy, was chief minister of the undivided Andhra Pradesh (2004-09).

The BJP has also recently changed its party president in these two states in a bid to boost its chances. In Telangana, which is going to polls later this year, the BJP has inducted Union minister of tourism G. Kishan Reddy in place of Bandi Sanjay. In doing so, the party hopes to iron out the issues between lateral entrants (defectors) and the original *karyakarthas* and get a concerted campaign effort going. The strategy is to make it a triangular contest in a bid to head off a resurgent Congress. In Andhra, the BJP has gone for a daring gambit by making Daggubati Purandeswari, the third daughter of Telugu Desam Party (TDP) founder N.T. Rama Rao and sister-in-law of ex-CM Chandrababu Naidu, the party chief. The plan is to wean away the influential Kamma caste cohort and deplete the TDP and Naidu of both cadre and funds in the hope of the BJP emerging as a viable alternative to Jagan's YSRCP.

The BJP is working on two other fronts, strengthening the party structure and reinventing the NDA. In Karnataka, there is concern that it may not be able to repeat its 2019 feat of winning 25 of the 28 Lok Sabha seats, especially after its humbling defeat at the hands of a resurgent Congress in the recent assembly election. So, the BJP is wooing H.D. Deve Gowda's Janata Dal (Secular) or JD(S) to ally with it to win seats in the old Mysuru region which is the party's stronghold. In Punjab, the party is in discussions to revive its alliance with the Shiromani Akali Dal (SAD). The BJP has been demanding more seats—seven of 13 for the Lok Sabha election (instead of three earlier) and 55 of 117 for the assembly poll (instead of the 23 earlier).



DEBAJYOTI CHAKRABORTY

THE BJP IS WORKING ON TWO FRONTS, BOLSTERING THE PARTY STRUCTURE AND REINVENTING THE NDA. AS PART OF THIS, THE NATIONAL AND STATE UNITS ARE ALSO BEING RESTRUCTURED

SECURING THE FORT

Even in Uttar Pradesh, which contributes 80 Lok Sabha seats and is considered a safe bastion, the BJP has drawn up plans to maximise its strength. The BJP alliance had won as many as 64 seats in 2019. Bolstering its efforts to retain them, it has prepared a separate plan to win the remaining 16 seats. The party is trying to win over Jat leader Jayant Chaudhary of the Rashtriya Lok Dal who had partnered with the Samajwadi Party (SP) led by Akhilesh Yadav in the 2022 assembly election. The BJP remains focused on retaining its substantial vote base among non-Yadav OBC communities that constitute 30 per cent of the population of the state. The party is perceived to be soft in its approach to Mayawati, the leader of the Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP), hoping that she will not join an Opposition alliance. Meanwhile, it is going all out to woo the Dalit votes on its own, including getting smaller parties to its fold. The BJP is also making efforts to win a section of Muslim votes by wooing the Pasmanda or backward classes among them who have influence in a dozen LS seats in the state.

BJP insiders believe that the lack of a cohesive opposition